Elias Elkoussa

Consultative Seller | Paid Media Strategy & AdTech
Dubai, United Arab Emirates
linkedin.com/in/elias-elkoussa-06a59b196/

PROFESSIONAL SUMMARY

Paid media and advertising professional with 18 years growing advertiser revenue across the GCC and wider Middle East, on the platform side (xAI, formerly Twitter, and Criteo) and the agency side (Universal Media, Mediacom). Managed annual client portfolios of up to $9M, partnering with senior marketing and agency leaders at brands and organizations including Etihad Airways, Department of Culture and Tourism – Abu Dhabi (DCT Abu Dhabi), Samsung, Huawei, Microsoft and The Coca-Cola Company. Built joint business plans and full-funnel paid media strategies, from brand to ROAS-led performance, that grew client investment, cross-sell and product adoption.

CORE SKILLS

Commercial: Strategic Account Management | Joint Business Planning | Revenue Growth | Cross-sell & Up-sell | Commercial Negotiation
Media: Full-funnel Media Strategy | Media Planning & Buying | Programmatic & AdTech | Digital Media | ROAS Optimization | Measurement & Tracking
Leadership: C-suite Stakeholder Management | Cross-functional Leadership | GCC & MENA Markets

PROFESSIONAL EXPERIENCE

Client Partner | Criteo | Dubai, UAE | March 2026 – September 2026

- Managed a $9M annual portfolio of travel-sector partnerships led by the Department of Culture and Tourism – Abu Dhabi (DCT Abu Dhabi) and Etihad Airways.
- Finalized a $5M joint business plan with DCT Abu Dhabi, a 20% increase in the account's billing.
- Delivered a multi-channel revenue tracking dashboard with Data Analytics, Technical Solutions and Product to estimate the revenue impact of DCT Abu Dhabi's advertising.
- Audited Etihad Airways' website and app with Technical Solutions and Product. This led to a joint business plan to optimize cost per flight search and ROAS; initial tests cut cost per flight search by 5%.
- Mapped Criteo's commerce data and Shopper Graph to the business challenges of marketing directors and paid media leads at DCT Abu Dhabi and Etihad Airways.

Senior Client Partner | xAI | Dubai, UAE | September 2019 – February 2026

- Managed an $8M annual portfolio of large GCC clients across technology, travel, CPG and others, partnering with executives, marketing directors and senior digital teams. Consistently met revenue targets and beat them in at least one quarter every year.
- Delivered 30% incremental revenue growth in the technology sector across Samsung, Huawei, Microsoft and Xbox by opening new markets and expanding product lines.
- Built a full-funnel strategy with Samsung to grow online sales through stronger sentiment, lower CPMs and more conversions. Samsung's KSA investment rose 25% in the first year, and cost per conversion fell 50% during that year's launches.
- Grew Huawei's investment on xAI by 50% in the first year and 10% the following year.

- Partnered with Tamam, a micro-financing solution, to map key purchasing opportunities through social listening and link them to customized creative messaging and audience segments, increasing applications from xAI by 10% over three months.
- Led commercial negotiations and structured local investment agreements that increased product adoption and year-over-year revenue.
- Designed customized solutions and investment frameworks with Product, Data, Marketing and Engineering to meet technology, travel, CPG and other sector KPIs.
- Ran training programs for technology, travel, CPG and other clients, and spoke at regional industry events, positioning xAI as a trusted strategic partner.

Media Director | Universal Media | Dubai, UAE | November 2014 – September 2019

- Led all paid media for The Coca-Cola Company, managing multi-million-dollar annual digital investment in brand campaigns measured on upper-funnel brand metrics.
- Designed Coca-Cola's digital framework, shifting from mass awareness campaigns to a customized six-persona framework and from reach and CPMs to brand love and brand favorability.
- Campaigns including "Share a Coke" and "Coke Studio" delivered 5–10% increases in brand love and favorability metrics, while the Smartwater launch reached 30–70% awareness across GCC markets in its first month.
- Ran co-funded campaigns and sponsored listings with commerce platforms Souq (now Amazon.ae) and Instashop to grow Coca-Cola's online sales.
- Grew the agency's digital campaign margins by more than 50% and added 30% in digital revenue for Universal Media through new targeting frameworks and in-house programmatic tools.
- Managed and mentored a team of eight, supporting leadership development and succession planning.

Media Manager | Mediacom | Dubai, UAE | August 2012 – November 2014

- Oversaw media strategy for major clients including Volkswagen, Shell, Dell and Sony Mobile Communications, focused on integrated digital planning and custom publisher partnerships.
- Ran media audits that saved clients more than 5% a year while maintaining campaign performance.
- Delivered strategic planning, market insights and performance analysis, working with clients, publishers and internal teams on tailored media solutions.

Media Supervisor | Universal Media | Dubai, UAE | December 2008 – August 2012

- Developed operational systems and automated reporting tools that cut reporting time by 10% and improved the efficiency of recurring media processes.

EDUCATION

American University of Sharjah | Bachelor's Degree in Management and Finance, Dual Major | July 2008
Honors Student | GPA: 3.68

LANGUAGES

English: professional (read and write) | Arabic: native (read and write)